

The Fans Remember

**Exploring practices of remembering in platform cultures along the case of
Game of Thrones fan videos on YouTube**

Materialities of communication understood as “the totality of phenomena contributing to the constitution of meaning without being meaning themselves.” (Gumbrecht and Pfeiffer 1994: 398). Put analytically, **reconstructing the structures and processes by which meaning can be articulated.**

**Meaning
structures**

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**Cultural
Moods**

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**Affective
engagement**

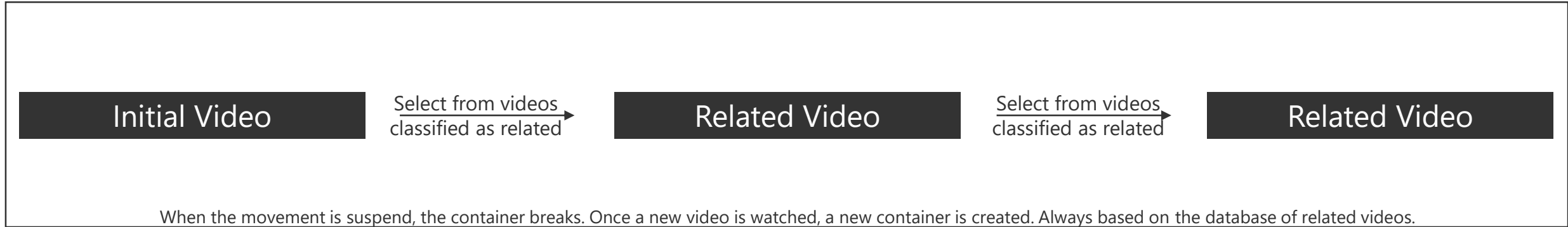
Identities, meanings, tastes, or other cultural properties understood as structures that seek to stabilize certain lifeways (Breiger 2007, Ikegami 2005, Fontdevila et al. 2011, Fuhse 2009, Mützel 2009).

Culturally and historically specific feelings of life and living. Reoccurring patterns of being touched by one's surrounding environment (Gumbrecht 1997, 2004, 2013, 2014).

Broadly understood as implication within the larger ecological becoming of the world where the human remains one among many elements (Hansen 2004a, 2004b, 2006, 2015).

- Emergent from practices of connection or implication.
 - Personal and communal meaning-structures (roles, tastes, expectations) which offer a guiding line in experiencing our environment.
 - Creative capacity to control, negotiate and maintain, lifeways under different and changing environmental conditions.
 - They are the structures that seek to enable making substantial and existential experiences in the future again.
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- Mediate between reason and emotion (Inspiration of the mind and an activation of the body).
 - Functioning through spatio-temporal arrangements, repeatedly shape and condition experiences of living and reliving life (Sublime and overwhelming processes in which contingency becomes order, being in and holding onto the things of the world).
 - Feeling of aliveness in states of high emotional and bodily awareness (being lost in focused intensity / being touched from the inside).
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- Technically exposing the ground upon which life (re)emerges.
 - Mediates pre-individual and individual being by adding something exterior.
 - Feeding forward this sensibility into individual phenomenal appearances.
 - Embodied experience highlighting not selection of relevant information but implication into presence and rhythms of audio-visuality.
 - Crucial nuance of Hansen's work, embodied experience and our life not understood through or with but in technology.

Audio-visual container



**Algorithmically ordered chain of videos that are classified as related
and available on the platform.**

or

**Assemblage in which people, machines, and audio-visual contents
interact and upon which cultural properties (can) emerge.**

“It is very important to try to understand the operation of a selective tradition. To some extent, the selection begins within the period itself; from the whole body of activities, certain things are selected for value and emphasis ... [S]elective tradition creates, at one level, a general human culture; at another level, the historical record of a particular culture; at third level, most difficult to accept and assess, a rejection of considerable areas of what was once a living culture.” (Williams 1961: 67)

"We are witnessing the transformation of amateur film culture ... from a focus on self-documentation toward a focus on an aesthetic based on appropriation, parody, and the dialogic.

"Coppola's 'little fat girl' has found a way to talk back to the dominant media culture, to express herself not simply within an idelect but within a shared language constructed through the powerful images and narratives that constitute contemporary popular culture.

"[O]nly if we maintain a vigorous and effective defence of the principle of 'fair use,' only if we recognize the rights of consumers to participate fully, actively, and creatively within their own culture, and only if we hold in check the desires of the culture industries to tighten their control over their own intellectual property in response to the economic opportunities posed by an era of media convergence." (Jenkins 2003).

This view allows us to understand what linked ecologies (Abbott 2005) are at and can be at work in contemporary popular culture. However, as these grounds increasingly emerge in digital settings, we also have to **understand the role algorithms play as entities equipped with agency and materiality**. They observe and adapt, classify and order, are adapted and changed. Most importantly, they are implemented on servers, have a runtime operation creating affective presences on the platform (MacKenzie 2016, Parisi 2013, Passoth 2017).

THE NORTH REMEMBERS



Ned, Benjen, and Robb

Core themes: Honor and Loyalty

- Edit is dramatic, music slow but images forward paced and fast moving
- Focus on action, lots of fighting scenes
- Making and highlighting narrative ties within the larger storyline
- *Less frequent but often high tier edits*



Brandon, Rickon, and Catelyn

Core themes: Courage and Strength

- Edit slow and dragging, follow and retell original storyline, lots of close-ups
- Focus on emotions and deep reading of the characters' meaningfulness
- Highlighting character diversity and Stark family virtues
- *Less frequent and often lower tier edits*

Arya, Sansa, and Jon

Core themes: Becoming and Identity

- Edit is dramatic, images and music are uprising, very rhythmic, don't retell original storyline but tell a story on its own
- Focus on identity struggle and development
- Show narrative ties but primarily seek to engage into the becoming of characters
- *Very frequent and often high tier edits*



House Stark

Core themes: Becoming and Home

- Edit is forward paced, lots of cross-cuts and voice overs, often action laden, large variety of musical genres and styles, often unrelated to GoT
- Focus on feelings / emotional journey of finding back to Home
- Shows key moments, parallels between characters, makes present the fall and rise of House Stark (though not the context of it)
- *Very frequent and majority high tier edits*



Data gathering:

- A related video network is the 'backbone' dataset upon which YouTube builds recommendations and personalization. Gives us an idea for what the contents on YouTube can look like for a broader variety of people.
- YouTube Data v3 API (public access).
- Top seeds from the search query (same results as when using native search via web interface).
- Related videos info for depths 0 and 1 (meaning, get related videos for initial seeds, depth 0, 1, for which again get related videos).

Network analysis:

Cluster through Louvain community detection algorithm (Blondel et al. 2008)

- Assumption is that YouTube creates relations based on similarity (Baluja et al 2008, Davidson et al 2010, Simonet 2013, Bendersky et al 2014).
- Louvain algorithm generates clusters by optimizing communities towards densely connected nodes.
- Commonly used and reliable community detection method to gain first insight into composition of large networks (Lancichinetti and Fortunato 2011, Papadopoulos et al. 2011, Orman et al. 2012).

Force-directed layout with scaled gravity

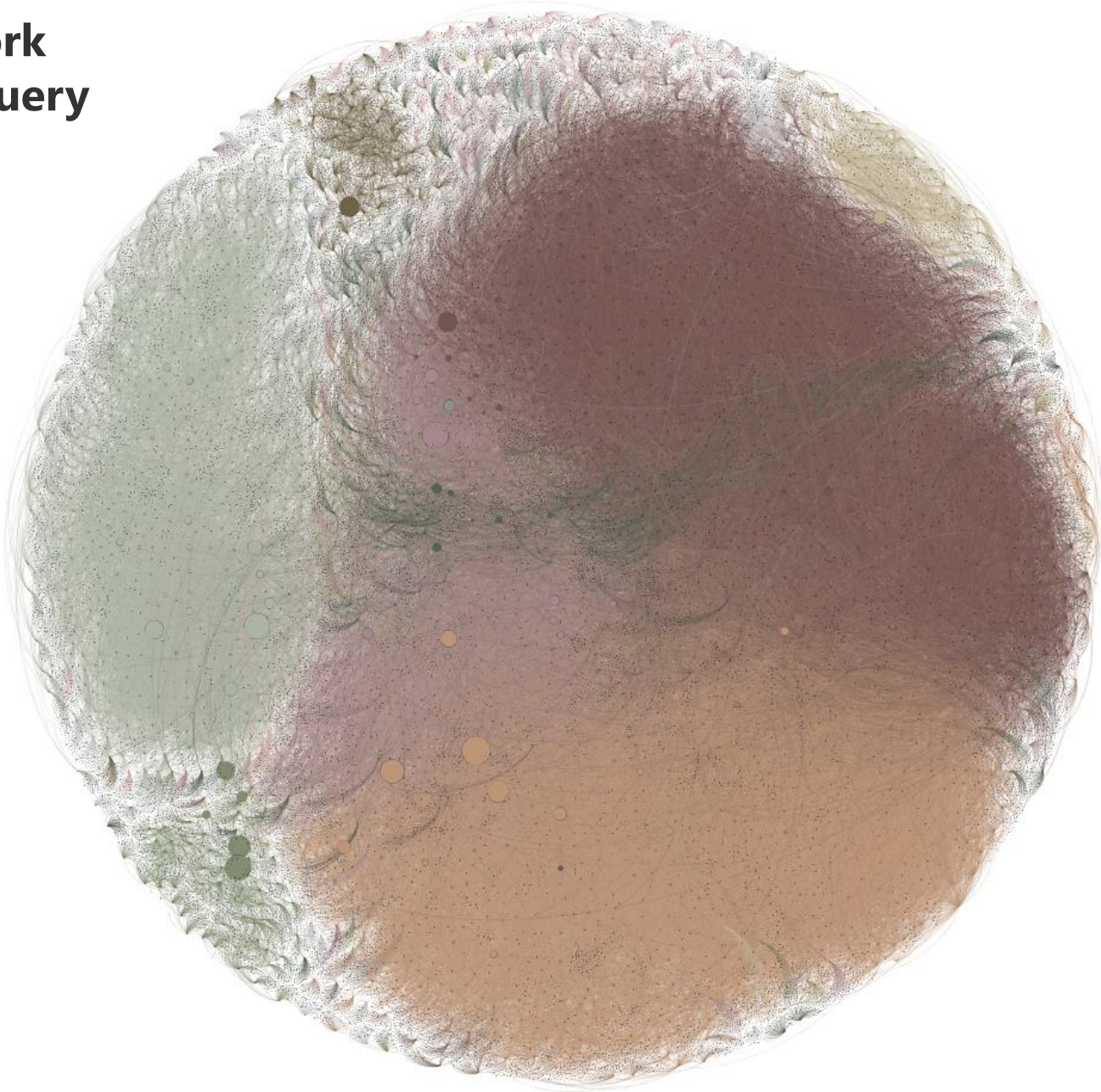
- Central nodes are placed centrally, cluster behave accordingly, gravity scaling enhances this by more compact and comparable spatialization (Bannister et al. 2013).

Content analysis:

Computationally supported content analysis (DiMaggio et al. 2013, Fuhse and Mützel 2011, Mützel 2015, Lewis et al. 2013, Lucas et al. 2015)

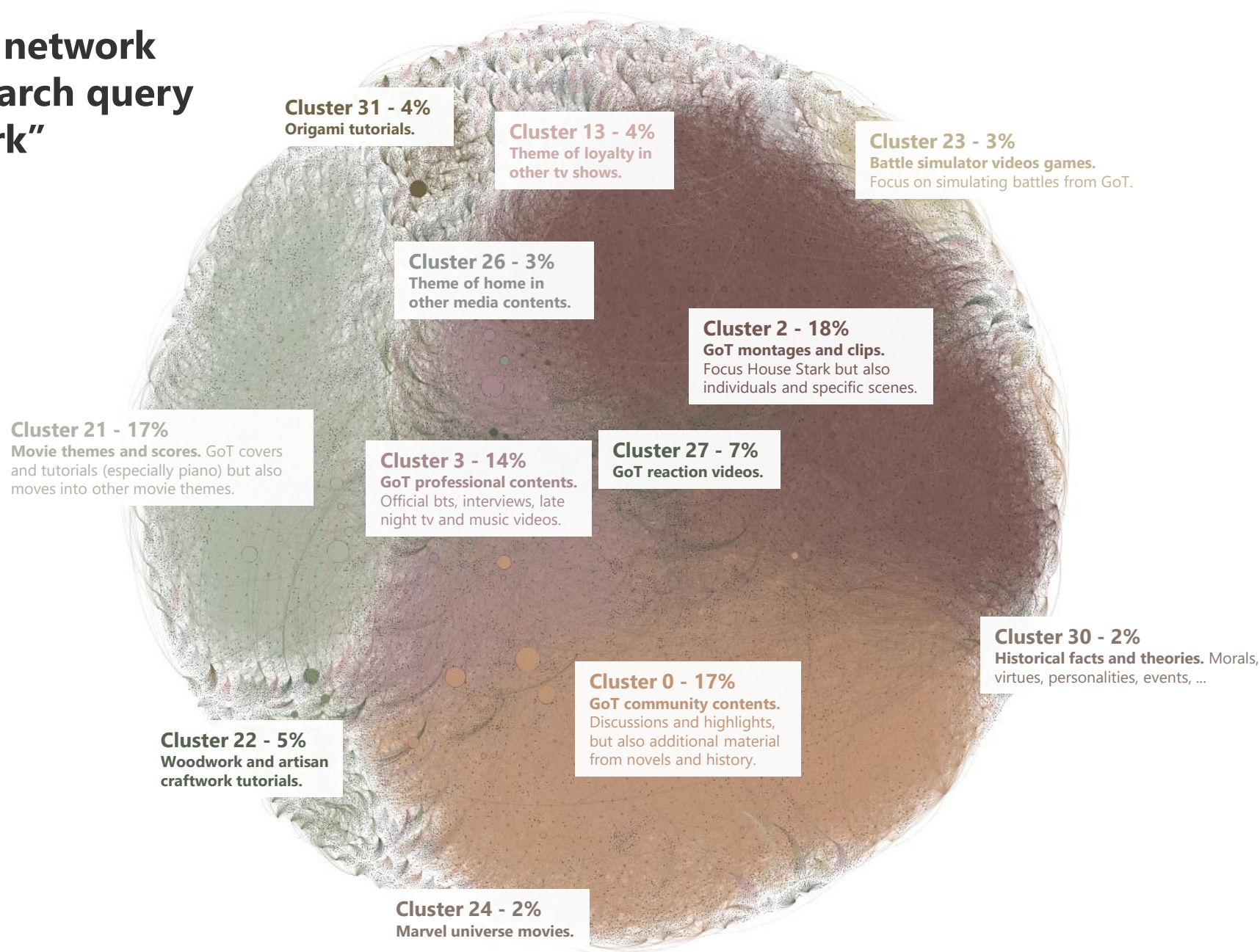
- Assessing themes of clusters through analysis of video titles and video tags (most operable considering size).
- (1) Inductive categorization of lower and upper bound of central (betweenness centrality) and influential nodes (view count and engagement ratio).
- (2) Extraction of central terms through analysis of co-occurrences (Deerwester et al. 1990, Lund and Burgess 1996).
- (3) Structural topic modelling for each corpus of video titles with centrality and influence measures as covariates (Roberts et al. 2013)

**Related videos network
for YouTube search query
“got house stark”**



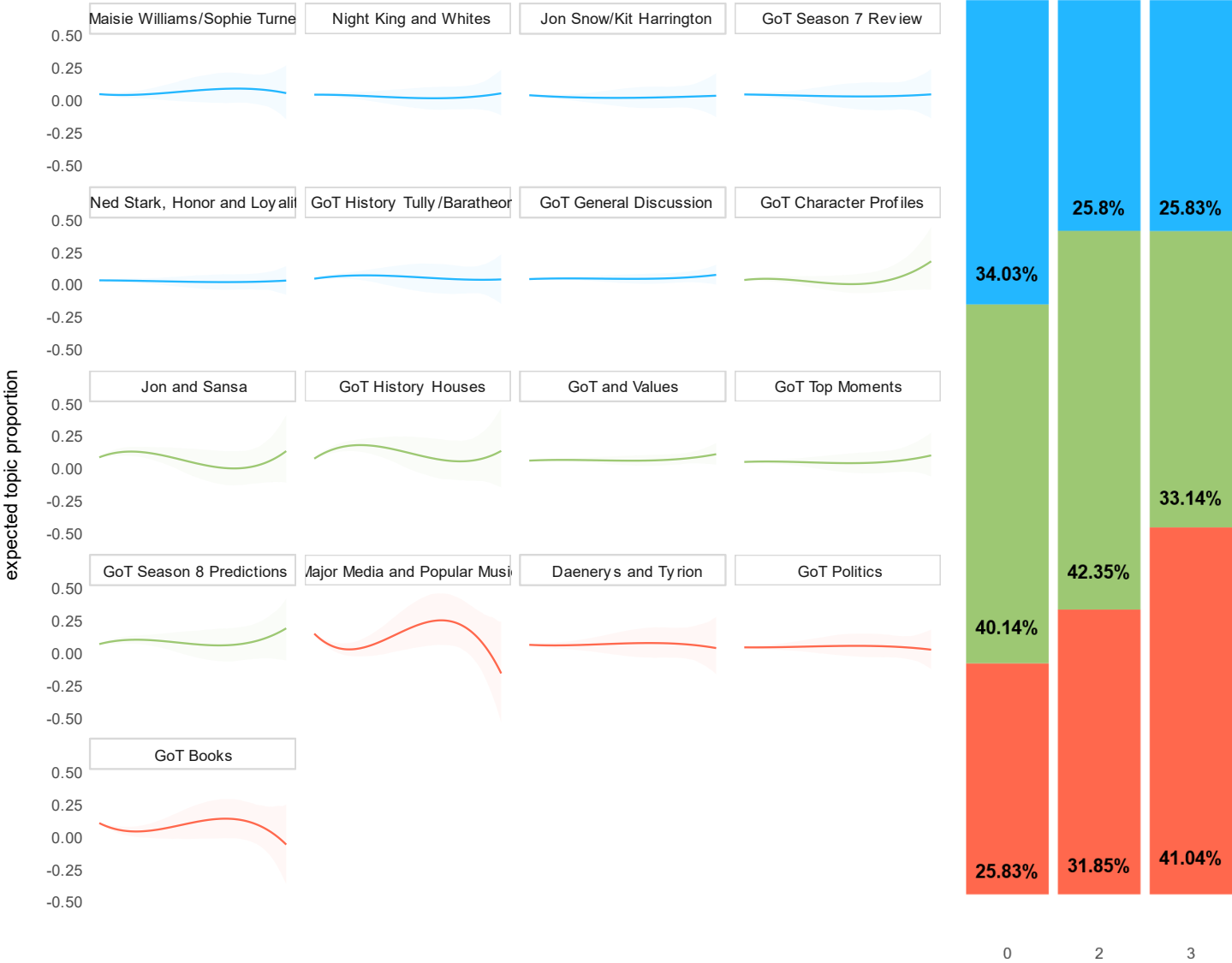
Nodes	36972
Edges	123310
Clustering coefficient	.11
Average degree	6.8
Diameter	17
Range clustering coefficient within clusters	.1 / .15
Clusters / colour by	Louvain Modularity
Node size by	Betweenness
Layout	ForceAtlas2

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Effects of betweenness centrality on topic distribution for Clusters 2, 3, and 0



Topics placed **neutral** by the algorithm are general discussion of GoT but also videos featuring the cast and interviews with them.

Topics **pushed** by the algorithm are especially montages of GoT characters and community videos concerning the upcoming seasons.

Topics **suspended** by the algorithm especially are major media and popular music contents but also videos discussing the GoT books.

However, note that these videos still make up 1/3 and more of the traffic!

“The target of control is not the production of subjects whose behaviours express internalized social norms; rather, control aims at a never-ending modulation of moods, capacities, affects, and potentialities, assembled in genetic codes, identification numbers, ratings profiles, and preference listings, that is to say, in bodies of data and information.” (Clough 2007: 19).

For many people, Game of Thrones matters. A site of popular culture, it allows them to make substantial experiences; be affected, attuned, to coordinate personal and communal being.

Montages created by the community are a vital means by which Game of Thrones today remains present part of popular culture even if the show itself is not on the air at the time. Yet further, this is not simply a selective memory emerging within such community practices. Rather an experiential field of its own. In rearranging and remixing the show within and with outside contents, not only (alternate) readings of it are being negotiated, but also feelings and emotions of it reactivated and uncovered.

Within these practices of a selective tradition, recommender algorithms increasingly play a important role. Doing so, they are not only active but also not neutral. However, to fully assess their domains of control, we are required a twofold move. Firstly, nurturing increased awareness for the activity of non-human actors engaging in the creation of our future cultures. This does, secondly, require an understanding of the grounds upon which people negotiate the freedoms and dominations that come with such domains of algorithmic control.

Thanks!

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